

What's Covered: AISH and ADAP, Side by Side

*Financial, health and personal benefits, with the two programs kept separate throughout —
Community Reference, July 2026*

How to read this. Part One is the plain-language summary. Part Two is the sourced reference with exact amounts, frequencies and limits. Wherever AISH and ADAP differ, the difference is called out. A recipient's program is stated in their own notification letter. Both columns are kept here so either can be read directly.

Before relying on any figure in this document

Benefit rates are adjusted annually, normally on January 1. The amounts here are current as of the July 2, 2026 policy manual and the May 12, 2026 fact sheet.

This document is prepared by a community campaign, not by the Government of Alberta. It is a reading of published material. Before acting on any amount, the program should be asked to confirm individual figures in writing.

No individual benefit amounts are calculated here. What a person receives depends on household composition, income and circumstances, and only the program can confirm an individual figure.

PART ONE — The plain-language version

The Health Benefits Card, in one line

The Health Benefits Card covers the client, a cohabiting partner and dependent children listed on it for prescription drugs, essential over-the-counter medications, dental care, eye exams and glasses, emergency ambulance, and essential diabetic supplies.

The card must be shown to the provider before the service is received. Where a person chooses to pay out of pocket, reimbursement will not be provided.

The card is the same under AISH and ADAP. Health coverage does not change between the two programs. What changes between AISH and ADAP is the money — the monthly allowance and the amount that can be earned from work — not the card.

The two programs at a glance

The headline: ADAP pays \$200 a month less in allowance, but permits considerably more employment income before the benefit is reduced. AISH pays more but effectively caps earnings at \$350 a month.

	AISH	ADAP
Who it is for	Severe disability that permanently prevents employment	Severe disability that substantially impedes employment
Monthly living allowance	\$1,940	\$1,740
Work expectation	None required	Expected to seek, accept and keep reasonable employment
Earnings fully exempt	\$350/month, then earnings reduce the benefit dollar for dollar	\$700 single / \$1,100 with children, then a gradual taper up to \$45,240/yr
Where work income ends eligibility	Moved to ADAP, or to Alberta Adult Health Benefit (AAHB)	Enduring Health Benefits (EHB) until age 65
Health Benefits Card	Same coverage	Same coverage

What the Health Benefits Card covers

- **Prescriptions and some over-the-counter items** — filled at any Alberta pharmacy, for anything on the Alberta Drug Benefit List.
- **Dental** — exams, cleanings, x-rays, fillings, extractions, dentures. Most procedures need pre-approval through Alberta Blue Cross, which the dental office arranges.
- **Eyes** — one eye exam every 24 months for adults; glasses covered. Children under 18 get their eye exams through Alberta Health, and the card replaces their glasses every 12 months.
- **Diabetic supplies** — test strips, lancets, insulin injection supplies, and a blood-glucose monitor once, up to \$70.
- **Emergency ambulance** — to the nearest hospital, inside Alberta.
- **Not on the card but available on request** — unusual or additional health needs go to the Health Benefits Exception Committee. One-time and special items such as special diets, equipment, moving costs and child care are separate personal benefits. See Part Two, Section C.

PART TWO — The sourced reference

Amounts, frequencies and limits below are drawn from the AISH and ADAP Policy Manual (updated July 2, 2026), the AISH General Regulation (AR 96/2026, in force July 2, 2026), and the ADAP fact sheet (May 12, 2026). Each block names its source.

A. Financial benefits

A1. Monthly living allowance (clients not in a facility)

	AISH	ADAP
Maximum monthly amount	\$1,940	\$1,740
Legal test	Severe disability that permanently prevents employment	Severe disability that substantially impedes employment
Where a partner is also on AISH or ADAP	\$1,707.20 (88%)	\$1,531.20 (88%)
Reduced by	Non-exempt income; group-home per-diem room and board	Non-exempt income; group-home per-diem room and board

Source: Policy Manual, Living Allowance; AR 96/2026 s.9(2)–(4). The 88% figures are calculated from the maximum rates and are shown to the cent. The exact amount should be confirmed against the individual benefit statement.

A2. \$200 monthly transition benefit (ADAP only)

Paid to former AISH clients who transitioned to ADAP on or after July 2, 2026, and to AISH clients who chose to move to ADAP. \$200.00 per month per client, from the August 2026 benefit period to December 2027. Reported in the manual as **not** reduced to 88% for couples, and as not counting against the \$5,000 personal-benefit asset limit. Clients receiving the modified (facility) living allowance are not eligible.

Source: Policy Manual, Transition Benefit; AR 96/2026 Schedule 3 s.13. AISH clients who remain on AISH do not receive it. In a two-client household, the program should be asked to confirm in writing how the transition benefit and the 88% calculation interact on that file.

A3. Modified living allowance (clients living in a facility)

Component	Monthly rate
Personal allowance	\$373 per month
Accommodation — private room	\$2,482 per month (\$81.60/day)
Accommodation — shared room	\$2,148 per month (\$70.60/day)

Source: Policy Manual, Modified Living Allowance (rates effective January 1 and April 1, 2026). Same structure under both programs. The personal allowance goes to the client; accommodation goes to the facility.

A4. Child benefit — same rates under both programs

Dependent child	Monthly amount
First or only child	\$300
Second child	\$117
Third child	\$88
Fourth child	\$59
Each additional child	\$30

Source: AR 96/2026 s.10(2); Policy Manual, Child Benefit. Effective from the August 2026 benefit period. One benefit per child even where both partners are eligible, with a shared-parenting exception under which each parent may receive the full benefit. The previous AISH rate was \$232 for a first child and \$117 for each additional child.

A5. Earnings exemptions — the core difference between the programs

	AISH	ADAP
Fully exempt each month	\$350	\$700 (single) / \$1,100 (with dependent children)
Above the exempt amount	Not exempt — reduced dollar for dollar	Partially exempt, gradual and progressive deduction
Annual earnings ceiling	Effectively capped near the monthly exemption	\$45,240 per year while still receiving financial benefits
Cohabiting partner, either program	\$1,500/month fully exempt, then progressive	\$1,500/month fully exempt, then progressive

Source: Policy Manual, Income Exemptions; ADAP fact sheet, May 12, 2026. The ADAP taper is described by the government as starting at less than a cent per dollar and increasing as earnings approach the annual ceiling. The operational rate table has not been published. A benefits calculator is available at alberta.ca/ADAP.

A6. Other income exemptions (both programs)

Exemption	Detail
Passive business income	Fully exempt: \$300 single / \$600 where there is a cohabiting partner or dependent child, then 25% of the amount above that is also exempt.
Spousal or cohabiting-partner pension income	From July 2026: the first \$1,200 per month fully exempt, plus 25% of the remainder. Listed types include Canada Pension Plan income, Employment Insurance and Workers' Compensation.
Canada Child Benefit (CCB)	Fully exempt. Not counted as income.
Canada Disability Benefit (CDB)	Non-exempt for standard clients — deducted dollar for dollar. Exempt for clients receiving the modified (facility) living allowance.

Source: Policy Manual, Income; ADAP fact sheet (spousal pension); AR 96/2026 Schedule 1 ss.1–3. Alberta is the only province or territory deducting the Canada Disability Benefit dollar for dollar.

A7. Asset limits (both programs)

Limit	Detail
Non-exempt assets	\$100,000 or less
Personal-benefit eligibility	\$5,000 or less in non-exempt assets, except for the transition benefit and financial-hardship situations.

Source: AR 96/2026 s.4(1)(c); Policy Manual, Personal Benefits.

B. Health benefits (the Health Benefits Card)

Health coverage is identical under AISH and ADAP. Clients, cohabiting partners and dependent children listed on a valid Health Benefits Card receive the following. Coverage is Alberta-only — costs incurred while travelling outside the province are not covered.

Benefit	What is covered, and the limits
Prescription drugs	Prescription and some over-the-counter drugs and nutritional products on the Alberta Drug Benefit List and Drug Benefit Supplement. Some require special authorization. Any Alberta pharmacy. Supply-day limits apply.
Essential diabetic supplies	Blood glucose test strips; lancets and penlets; glucose calibration solution; a blood-monitoring device, physician-authorized, one time, up to \$70. For insulin users: needles, syringes and pen needles.
Dental services	Basic coverage: complete, recall and emergency exams, cleaning, x-rays, fillings, extractions, dentures and other services, through Alberta Blue Cross agreements. Most procedures need pre-authorization. Providers cannot bill above the fee schedule.
Optical services	One routine eye exam every 24 months for adults, and for 18 and 19 year olds attending high school. Eyeglasses covered, with replacement after 24 months for adults or 12 months for dependent children under 18. Contact lenses only for specific conditions. Alberta Health covers eye exams for children under 18.
Emergency ambulance	Cost of emergency ambulance to the nearest hospital within Alberta, where the person is on a valid card and no other insurer is responsible. Where other coverage exists, the program pays the difference up to Alberta Health's maximum.
Additional or exceptional needs	Medically essential items outside normal card coverage go to the Health Benefits Exception Committee. Decisions are final and are exempt from appeal, but a request may be resubmitted where the situation has changed or new and compelling information is available. Normally decided within 10 business days.

Source: Policy Manual, Health Benefits.

B1. Keeping health coverage after leaving the program

	AISH	ADAP
Where eligibility is lost because of the client's own work income	Moved to ADAP, or to Alberta Adult Health Benefit (AAHB) for health coverage.	Enduring Health Benefits (EHB) — health coverage continues without interruption until age 65.
Eligible for Enduring Health Benefits?	No	Yes
Where lost due to CPP-D or a partner's work income	Alberta Adult Health Benefit (AAHB)	Alberta Adult Health Benefit (AAHB)
Personal benefits under AAHB or EHB?	Not provided	Not provided

Source: Policy Manual, Alberta Adult Health Benefit and ADAP Enduring Health Benefits. AAHB benefit year runs October 1 to September 30. EHB requires assets of \$100,000 or less and Alberta residency. Note that the covered medical assessment for reassessment does not apply to clients enrolled in AAHB or ACHB.

C. Personal benefits (one-time and ongoing special needs)

Personal benefits assist with specific one-time or ongoing needs. They are mostly identical under AISH and ADAP, with one ADAP-only exception. Eligibility generally requires non-exempt assets of \$5,000 or less. Personal-benefit *rates* are not appealable, and personal benefits are not provided through AAHB or EHB.

C1. ADAP-only personal benefit

Employment and Training Supports. AISH clients are not eligible for this personal benefit. ADAP clients may receive costs up to \$590.00 in a 12-month period, and may also be eligible for the travel benefit.

C2. Personal benefit rates

Personal benefit	Rate or limit
Child care (private)	\$9.00/hour for the first child plus \$6.00/hour for each additional child, to a maximum of \$15.00/hour. Licensed day care: parent portion plus deposits and fees.
Children's school expenses	\$63/yr (preschool, age 4+), \$121/yr (grades 1–6), \$208/yr (grades 7–12), per child, plus the cost of lunch-hour supervision.
Emergency benefit	Food \$26/day per client and \$20/day per child; replacement clothing \$253 client / \$190 child; damage deposit; utility or rental arrears; essential repairs; accommodation up to two weeks; up to \$1,177 per circumstance for a one-time item.
Infant care	One-time \$296.00 per dependent infant child.
Establishing a new residence	Full cost up to \$1,177.00.
Moving	The most economical cost.
Remote community	\$48.00/month per client and per dependent child.
Medical supplies	Reasonable cost up to \$473.00 per month.
Medical equipment	Up to \$2,351.00 per item. CPAP: fixed-pressure up to \$1,999.00 once every three years; auto-pressure up to the medical-equipment maximum once every three years.
Maintenance of equipment	Manual and power wheelchair and power scooter maintenance at set rates.
Specialized clothing	Reasonable cost up to \$354.00 in a 12-month period.
Service animal	\$63.00 per month.
Medical alert service	Reasonable cost, set-up and ongoing; least costly option.
Travel	Most economical cost; rural address up to \$496.00 round trip.
Funeral benefits	Set categories (ceremony, embalming, transport, cemetery).

Source: Policy Manual, Personal Benefits; rates per Ministerial Order 2018-21 (Personal Benefit Rates and Frequencies); funeral categories per Ministerial Order 2023-028.

C3. Special diets (both programs) — monthly rates, with a physician or dietitian letter

Special diet	Monthly rate
Low sodium / high protein / high fibre / high calcium / lactose free	\$26 each
Pregnancy (until birth)	\$32
Breast feeding	\$37
High calorie / AIDS or HIV / Hepatitis C	\$44 each
Heart healthy / diabetic	\$48 each
Milk free	\$63
Celiac / gluten free	\$95
Malabsorption or insufficiency (highest listed)	\$132

Source: Policy Manual, Special Diets rate table. A combined rate may apply where more than one diet is required; some combinations are restricted.

D. AISH and ADAP — the differences that matter most

	AISH	ADAP
Monthly allowance	\$1,940	\$1,740
Medical test	Permanently prevents employment	Substantially impedes employment, continuously or episodically
Work obligation	None required	Must seek, accept and keep reasonable employment
Earnings fully exempt	\$350/month, then dollar-for-dollar reduction	\$700 single / \$1,100 with children, then tapered to \$45,240/yr
Enduring Health Benefits to 65	Not eligible	Eligible
Employment and Training Supports	Not eligible	Up to \$590 per 12 months
\$200 transition benefit	Only where a client moves to ADAP	Yes, if transitioned — August 2026 to December 2027
Health Benefits Card coverage	Identical	Identical
Child benefit, assets, modified allowance	Identical	Identical

Sources and caveats

- AISH and ADAP Policy Manual, last updated July 2, 2026.

- AISH General Regulation, AR 96/2026 — filed May 12, 2026, in force July 2, 2026. Governs both AISH and ADAP.
- ADAP fact sheet, alberta.ca, May 12, 2026.
- Health Benefits Card letter issued to recipients, July 2026.
- Amounts are current as of the July 2, 2026 manual. Core benefits are normally adjusted every January 1, so the figures here will change.
- A recipient's program is stated in their own notification letter. Both columns are kept here so either can be read directly.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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